

Ataturk's military-backed secularism. At an explicit show at a gay nightclub in Istanbul, a companion whispers: "This is why we'll never be Iran." But during an extended stay in Iran, Taseer finds that the IIT-educated Iranian who raised the flag of the Iranian revolution at the Delhi embassy in 1979 is now a rich businessman, and a student in Yazd says: "Our revolution has expired." While circling the Kaba at Mecca, he feels he's a fraud, for hiding the Shiva tattoo on his arm (graven image, inimical to Islam) or the fraying threads round his wrist and neck. They're from Sufi shrines, he explains. "Don't say that," says his Saudi friend. "That's even worse. The Wahhabis hate Sufis."

His travels peak in Pakistan but it is not an easy homecoming. The question of his double identity

EXCERPT

Once the car had driven away, and we were half-naked specks on the marble plaza, Hani said, 'I'll read and you repeat after me.' His dark, strong face concentrated on the page and the Arabic words flowed out.

Kareem, pale with light eyes, and handsome, also muttered the words. We stood close to each other in our pilgrims' clothes—two white towels, one round the waist, the other across the torso, leaving the right shoulder bare.

'I seek refuge in Allah the Great, in His Honourable Face and His Ancient Authority from the accursed Satan. Allah, open the doors for me the doors of Your Mercy.'

It was a clear, mild night and we were standing outside the Grand Mosque in Mecca. The plaza was vast, open and powerfully floodlit.

haunts him on a trip with a feudal lord in Sind. "Come on, you're Muslim. If your father's Pakistani, you're Muslim," says a fellow traveller when Taseer confesses that as a product of an inter-faith marriage he's nothing, neither Sikh nor Muslim. And how do the long-awaited father-son encounters pan out—in recrimination or rapprochement? Predictably, they are fraught with all the emotional and political baggage of the larger India-Pakistan relationship.

Taseer's troubles did not end with completing this book. The manuscript was vetted for libel in the West and he had to change his publisher mid-stream in India. As lost-and-found stories go, Taseer has found himself a full-time vocation as a writer after his brave and beautifully crafted debut. His next book, a novel titled *The Temple-Goers* and set in Delhi, is awaited with anticipation next year. ■

Art Therapy

Characters in this graphic novel find solace in the art of storytelling

By Saurabh Singh



THE HOTEL
AT THE END OF
THE WORLD
by PARISMITA SINGH
Penguin India
Price: Rs 350
Pages: 138

It is fitting that the location of the hotel is not specified anywhere in the story because like the title suggests, this hotel is precariously balanced at the edge of the rational world, teetering into the realm of folklore and mythical anecdotes passed down from generation to generation. On a rainy afternoon, two expeditioners seek refuge from the rain and thus starts an exchange of stories between everyone present in the room. The listeners sit quietly waiting for their turn, seemingly aware of the ever-changing details in the stories and yet playing along with the storyteller. An expedition led by a mysterious cellphone that receives directions via SMS, encounters with the spirits of ancient soldiers, star-crossed lovers and fathers caught in impossible dilemmas—these fantastic narrations bring out the desire to experience something extraordinary in their otherwise mundane existence, to be part of something that is worth narrating. From the blind old man who fantasises about a beautiful tragedy to which he loses his eyes to the middle-aged woman who wishes that her romance had ended in a more spectacular fashion, *The Hotel at the End of the World* is the story of a community that collectively finds solace in the therapeutic art of storytelling. Perhaps this hotel isn't really very far away and with a little effort, we can easily find it all around us.

Not long ago, there was a time when the inclusion of images with the written word meant compromising the literary credibility of a piece of writing. Illustrated stories were meant for non-serious readers and children. Comics were as important as candy, seen as harmful by some and much reviled in general. So the comic industry resorted to coin a new term—graphic novel—so that these books are revisited, free from the stigma and prejudice that comics carried with them. Grown-ups can now enjoy these picture books without feeling guilty of consuming lightweight entertainment and this title is another successful attempt in this upcoming genre. Parismita Singh picks the right stories to put the point across and tells them with panache. ■